

MIGHTY TUSKS

MAMMUTHUS

An extinct relative of modern-day elephants, *Mammuthus* once roamed the grasslands of the Northern Hemisphere, sharing its habitat with early humans. The best-known species was *Mammuthus primigenius*, or the woolly mammoth. This animal only became extinct relatively recently, with a small population surviving on an Arctic island up until just 4,000 years ago. Paleontologists have found several specimens of both calves and adults that were very well preserved thanks to the frosty environment in which they lived and died. As a result, this prehistoric creature is well studied.

AT A GLANCE

- **HEIGHT** 11 ft (3.4 m)
- **DIET** Herbivore
- **LIVED** 200,000–4,000 YA
- **HABITAT** Grasslands



The woolly mammoth's long, curved tusks were probably used for display, competing for mates, and to brush snow off the grass before eating it.



COAT CLUES

Paleontologists have obtained strands of hair from mammoth fossils that tell us that these creatures were covered in thick, dark brown or blonde fur. Their coats would have kept them warm as they lumbered around their cold habitat.

Grass eater

Studies done on woolly mammoth teeth have revealed that their diet consisted of tough grasses. During the lean winter months, when vegetation was scarce, fat stores inside their bodies would have kept them going.

